

# Alienation of the Other

## Examining Marginal Narratives in Select Punjabi Films

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The history of Punjabi cinema, in 90 years of its evolution and development, is the history of exclusion of Dalit narratives.<sup>1</sup> Just as the contradictions of caste in Punjab, despite a general decrying of its presence, have proceeded through a complex dynamics of interplay between religion, the dominant presence of Jats, and constant othering and alienation of the other communities, the cinematic sphere also appears to reinforce the same divisions (Jodhka 2004; Judge 2002; Puri 2003).<sup>2</sup> It creates an essentialised image of Punjabiya with Jats as the prototypes of this identity, thereby evoking an imagined reality that seemingly deny ‘Dalits lives in their entirety and subtlety’ (Valmiki 2003: vii).<sup>3</sup> The presence of caste alienates the subject itself, and cinema with its power of maintaining dominant cultural hegemony also contributes to invisibilising Dalit experiences from the cultural sphere. This othering manifests itself in various ways; it forces the subject to accept the highly unjust social order to be natural and seemingly endless, hence alienating them from participation in the public sphere. This chapter explores the alienation of the Other and its unfolding in the Punjabi cinematic space. It takes up three different representations of caste in Punjabi cinema to unravel different aspects of alienation that Dalits are subjected to. *Anhey Ghere da Daan* (2011) through cinematic techniques encompassing the Deleuzian idea of ‘time-image’ and treating space as a character represents socio-cultural alienation of the marginalised. The movie *Chamm* (2017) places their alienation within the larger domain of social and economic exclusion. The third film *Landless* (2018) explores the changing dynamics of caste and land relations in Punjab.

Alienation understood in a general and abstract manner connotes ‘a surrender of control through separation from an essential attribute of the self’,<sup>4</sup> and in more concrete terms, the detachment of the subject from the material conditions in the absence of meaningful agency. Marx defines alienation of the labour in a capitalist society in four different ways, namely alienation from the products of labour; alienation from the activity of labour; alienation from the self’s own humanity, and alienation from the society (2007). While Marx specifies different aspects of alienation in relation to the capitalist mode of production, we contend about alienation experienced by Dalits suffering under caste hierarchy in a feudal structure and neoliberal mode of production. To understand the complexities of alienation, we take cognisance of the

relationship between power and othering and how it affects the lives of Dalits, often alienated from society as a whole. Alienation is not just limited to subjective experience but it also entails objective structures that the mainstream Punjabi cinema often chooses to ignore. We argue that the rural and urban continuum of alienation, while its nature can be different in these films, not only conveys the notion of exclusion but also allows the existing status quo of caste hierarchy to remain in a state of permanence. The state of liminality that the characters live through, does not remain transient but becomes a permanent part of their existence. Finally, in considering the question of alienation and othering, we assert the need to locate it within the construction of 'Punjabi' identity in Punjabi cinema.

### ***Anhey Ghorey Da Daan: Spatial and Temporal Alienation***

*Anhey Ghorey Da Daan* (hereafter, *AGDD*) foregrounds the temporal and spatial alienation of the marginalised.<sup>5</sup> Directed by Gurvinder Singh and based on the eponymous novel by Gurdial Singh, the film uses the ancient myth, which can be understood as an allegory of the Marxist idea of alienation of the individuals from the fruitions of one's labour.<sup>6</sup> Just as the Asuras were forced to be dependent upon the Devtas, Dalits had to remain dependent on the upper castes for compensation. The mythical and the Marxist ideas run in a parallel manner; both reach out to the pressing concern of spatial alienation through the story of a Dalit father, who lives in the village, and his son, Melu who lives in the city. The father struggles to join other men of his community to seek justice for Dharma, a Dalit tenant forcibly evicted and arrested for occupying a house that has been sold by the landlord. Melu, a rickshaw-puller, wanders around in the city but failing to find any repose, returns to the village at the end of the film. In the absence of chronological temporality, events occur often with no allusion to a particular time frame and at the same time manage to complete a diurnal incessant cycle. The film starts with the call for alms in the name of blind horse and almost ends with the same call. The mundane cycle is completed, portraying the lives of the characters to be stuck within this one day which they have to re-live countless times.

Following Mani Kaul, Singh proceeds by problematising the conventional understanding of cinematic form and meaning; he focuses his attention on 'a flow of duration seeping through an ellipsis between image and sounds', in turn conveying the experience of human subjectivity through an exploration of time (Kaul 2018: 46).<sup>7</sup> His focus on 'duration' through a usage of exceedingly long shots taken through a wide-angle lens running over a span of a few minutes also resonates with what Gilles Deleuze calls 'time-image'. Building upon Henri Bergson's time and duration, Deleuze conceptualises duration as a metric to understand the new founded subjectivity inherent to post-World War II cinema. Bergson distinguishes between two different types of time: spatialised time and the real time or duration. While spatialised time is divisible, immobile, and abstract, duration is defined as 'lived experience as a variation of internal psychological states' (1989: 37). Extrapolating this concept, Deleuze understands duration as a whole which cannot be divided into separate moments. He 'reconceptualizes the immobile sections in cinema as the objects in the frame and this allows him to show that cinema can indeed produce movement as a mobile section of duration' (Poell 2004: 7). Its objective is not to show a linear progression of events; rather it rebukes the cause-and-effect paradigm. Deleuze contends that through montage and mobility of the camera, the shot can show the relationship between the object and the whole. Maintaining this, Deleuze distinguishes cinema into two types: 'movement image' and 'time image'. He argues that if movement is not directed towards a centre which creates a whole, and this centre is not able to capture action and reaction, then time image emerges, in which time is presented directly. However, this time is not 'real time' but

‘duration’. This understanding of cinematic aesthetics in terms of duration and ‘qualitative space-time variant’ in *AGDD* helps to heighten the spatial alienation that all the characters experience at different levels (Kaul 2013: 13). For instance, the long shots of the befuddled father standing in the empty-cobbled street, the father silently witnessing the arrest of his friend, frantic Melu wandering aimlessly in his rickshaw, and his sister, Dayalo, restlessly running away in the streets at night make use of the experience of duration, which captures the essence of alienation, promulgated by the objective conditions within the space they are inhabiting.

Dalit houses in rural Punjab are often situated geographically at the margins of the villages and people living in them are often labelled as *Vehre aale* (outskirts dwellers). This marginalisation comes with an economic brunt of being landless and a sociological brunt of being the ‘other’. It is further extrapolated in the urban areas where the same dictum of marginalisation is followed, albeit not through the consent of people sharing the limited space but by the economic status of landless Dalits who leave their villages with hopes of having a space of their own in the cities. The absence of belongingness in both urban and rural spaces catapults them in a vortex of alienation where they seek escape by running from one space to the other. In the film, the first ever shot of the city is placed during a protest by the local Rickshaw Union, which provides a sense of purgation from the long-withheld agony of the characters but only to realise that it is later dispersed by the police. All the protesters in the city are linked by their labour, unlike villages where the community shares the space because of caste-based housing. Cityscape gives a sense of freedom from feudal oppression at the cost of one’s anonymity. The anonymous nature of countless workers protesting in the middle of the city gives a momentary hope for the disempowered. However, the characters experience restlessness, failing to gain a sense of repose. It has to be lived, in both the city and the village alike. Singh foregrounds this alienation in the cityscape through adroit tropes such as Melu never finding a place to rest, people living in close proximity to the railway tracks, slum settlements in the suburbs, and Melu and his friends scrounging from one place to other to sit and drink. At the end of the film, Melu returns to his village, while his father sets out for the city, thereby affirming both the city and the village as what David Sibley calls ‘geographies of exclusion’ for the marginalised and creating a pattern of their exclusion.<sup>8</sup>

At the village as well, all characters experience a crisis of their own which they fail to resolve. For instance, the close-up shots of Melu’s father in which he is either contemplating about the unrest around him or grappling with his own position in his home as the patriarch meticulously rendering the rupture of his sense of identity. His movements are unhurried and imperceptive, often providing the stillness of being, bereft of any social and cultural security (see Figure 21.1). Other characters fail to gain a sense of subjecthood due to constant undermining of their being by discrimination, impoverishment, and emasculation.<sup>9</sup> The superimposition of caste strictures on different aspects of their lives to subjugate them produce what Foucault calls, ‘docile bodies’ (1977: 136). There is an erosion of agency, a loss of self-worth. For instance, Melu, his father, and other people of their community, out of anxiety to save their bodies, wrap their shawls and *khes* (cotton blanket) even more tightly around their bodies, when challenged by the oppressive environment as if they have nothing else to belong to other than their bodies. A calculated constraint runs slowly through each part of their bodies. Often marked by the violence of constant degradation and humiliation, their ‘docile bodies’ are completely dissociated from power, turning their relation—with the village and its environment—to strict subjection.

Time in the film does not seem a gradual and encompassing moment but acts as a medium which entails past, present, and future together in a permanent stasis of being. This state of permanence lets the audience feel the liminality of the characters as is discernible in the case of Dayalo. Her attempt at purgation by running away aimlessly in the middle of the night is an



*Figure 21.1* Melu's father from the film *AGDD*.

*Source:* National Film Development Corporation of India.

act of the whole community to gain freedom from this endless cycle. She becomes the proxy of the microcosm she inhabits and her internal psychological states are rendered by the usage of time as 'duration'. Singh draws out the concluding scene using a frame-within-frame sequence to bring into focus the narrow-cobbled pathways and mist-covered constricting space to highlight how limiting the open streets are for the two protagonists when they are forced to face each other and end their little voyage. In the process, duration becomes a veritable medium of space. The act of Melu coming back to his village is not a grand gesture of the lost hero coming back to his roots but is a marker of acceptance of not only his present state of vulnerability but also the future that does not hold any promise.

The relationship with space influences the way the marginalised communities resist against the societal structures. In the village, Dalits fail to rise against the oppressors despite their shared grievances. When the whole congregation marches to the Sarpanch's house (the village head), their yomp is seen through the perspective of other villagers, supposedly upper caste. This exceedingly long shot exemplifies how Singh uses temporal sensitivity in a Deleuzian manner; he actively fixes the frame such that the congregation becomes a medium to convey the inherent subjectivity of the village populace. People busy with their work, heavy background noise speaking for their taciturn demeanour, and their direct gaze at the collective march signify their position in this matter. Singh questions the collective consciousness of people cohabitating the same space but prioritising their personal gratification in the face of a travesty of the Dalit populace. Upon their arrival at the Sarpanch's house, the congregation stands at the dome-shaped entrance and converses across the hypothetical border which Dalits are not supposed to cross. While the group is shown as a whole, with all the members in the frame (Figure 21.2), the shot of the Sarpanch is shown as a close-up, as if to contrast the helplessness of the collective in the face of a powerful individual. Through a wide-angle shot, we see the full view of the Sarpanch's house with all the amenities the congregation could only dream of. There is a rather dry exchange of spats between the two parties through which Singh conveys the alienation of the oppressed as the power equations distinctively favour the upper caste.



Figure 21.2 'Dalit congregation at Sarpanch's house' from the film *AGDD*.

Source: National Film Development Corporation of India.

### **Chamm: Alienation and Social Exclusion**

Directed by Rajeev Kumar, who was influenced by the alternative theatre of late Gursharan Singh,<sup>10</sup> the film *Chamm* relies on the theatrical mode to unfold alienation through social exclusion and oppression. Since its first screening at Barnala in 2017, it has been shown at 400 different places including some of the protest sites.<sup>11</sup> It narrates the story of Keepa, whose job involves removing skin from the dead animals. Failing to use Dalits as a vote bank in their enlarged political plans, the Sarpanch, who belongs to the Jat caste, imposes a condition to raise INR 45,000 to retain the space to skin animals. The film provides insights into caste equations as it follows Keepa's struggle with raising money and handling his family's economic woes. A veterinary doctor rents out a room at his house and pushes to mobilise Dalits towards claiming their share in the common land of the village.<sup>12</sup> The film ends with collective farming as a possible solution to their problems.

The film opens with a song titled 'Begumpura', a term coined by Sant Ravidas, envisioning the utopian ideal of a casteless and classless society where there is no fear, sorrow, suffering, or discrimination.<sup>13</sup> Utopia is a major motif in the film, and Kumar plays with the binary of utopia and lived reality. The lyrics describe Begumpura as a land with no taxes, terror, or wrongdoing, where there is no hierarchy but all are equal. The film locates itself in the midst of the huge gap between the Dalit aspiration for a casteless society and their lived reality in the contemporary Punjabi society, which entails caste oppression, social and political exclusion, violation and humiliation of women, underscoring of their vulnerability, apathy of the political and feudal representatives. The lived reality is still very distant from the utopian vision of Begumpura.

*Chamm* is emblematic for capturing the aspirations of the marginal lives which are not rooted in the traditional occupation. In fact, in the tension between two brothers—Keepa and Mewi—one senses this anxiety in the younger brother to dissociate himself from the ancestral occupation of dealing with the cattle and move to the city for alternative sources of livelihood. However,

this experience of mobility for Mewi is not an easy process. The film places him between the market economy as a possible flight from the village and equally powerful forces that tend to maintain him in a subjugated state. The city is shown as a new escape route, where the mall, with its multiple amenities and social privileges, becomes an allegory of power that enraptures Mewi. But his existence, like most others of his community in the village, remains a constant struggle between anger and powerlessness. The possibility that Mewi can aspire to a good life in the city with a capacity to spend and visit malls does not subdue or end his marginal status, rather it hints towards his alienation despite a spatial shift. This anxiety to distance himself from the village economy is further exacerbated by the political marginalisation of Keepa and other members of his caste, treated merely as a vote bank by the upper-caste political representatives.

Kumar foregrounds one particular aspect of Punjab, a state which can be seen as an outlier in terms of the practice of caste since it lacks the epistemological basis for stratification of the social order.<sup>14</sup> The consistent belief in two contradictory realities, one where Sikhism is propagated as the harbinger of the oppressed and as an anti-caste sect, where the welfare of the community is supreme and only humanism persists, and the other an objective reality marked by the clear demarcation of caste roles and concrete caste-based structures such as landholding, political power, and cultural hegemony mark the distinctiveness of contemporary Punjab. In one of the key scenes, the Sarpanch vehemently denies the presence of caste and quotes Guru Gobind Singh, 'Manas ki jaat, sabh ek pehchanbo' (Recognise the whole human race as of one caste). The Sarpanch firmly believes in the tenets of Sikhism as he proclaims while lamenting that caste is an illusion and all are created equal, 'I make sure to visit gurudwara twice every day' (*Chamm* 00:9:16–00:9:24). Harish Puri argues that the popular image of Sikhism tends to deny the presence of caste 'purely on the basis of scriptural ideology' (2003: 2695). However, social relations in the village economy are closely structured around caste, which never 'function as pure ideological systems' (Jodhka 2004: 189). Every time the question of caste arises in Punjab, long poetic verses are dug out to delegitimise the persistence of caste as exemplified by the Sarpanch. Envisioning Sikhism as a casteless sect is nullified by the struggles of Dalits who, having been ousted by Hinduism in medieval Hindu society, are denied dignity in modern Punjab. This raises another problem, the problem of reformist theological legitimacy and fluidity of caste-based oppressive structures in Indian society. Almost all reformist sects in one way or the other start pandering to modified versions of Brahmanism. Sikhism is one of the many contemporary examples which embodies the failure of caste-abolitionist reformist sects of Indian society. This failure, however, is yet to be recognised in Punjab.

*Chamm* is placed in this spatial and temporal context where characters cannot make any sense of the rampant exploitation they are subjected to. The contradictory realities and their perceptions by the individuals alienate the Dalits in their own sphere where any path towards emancipation seems desolate. This haunting sense of misery generated by being ousted from different spheres lurks throughout the film. The doctor, whose caste is never specified in the film, tries to mobilise Dalits to claim their share in the common land; however, the way she proposes and executes this transformation by obliterating the social boycott and other forms of violence seems simplistic and trivial in nature. In her conversation with Keepa's wife, she asseverates caste as an idea rather than placing it in material conditions with no acknowledgement of caste-complexities in Punjab. Her efforts to mobilise the Dalits speak volumes about her own belief in morality than about the actual collective action of Dalits. The doctor's constant belief that it is her individual responsibility to make Dalits conscious of their rights places her in the position of a saviour. Her categorisation of Dalits as 'eh lok' (these people) marks this binary, where the self and the other are distinctly demarcated. This upper-caste ignorance marks one deterrent that Kumar fails to acknowledge. The portrayal of Dalits as naive folks who cannot speak up

for themselves and the need that some other powerful figure must speak for them marks the distinctive Savarna understanding of Dalit cinema in the Indian subcontinent (Dwyer 2006; Vidushi 2015; Yengde 2018). The way the film presents naivety and the almost total absence of consciousness on their part despite the village life being ensconced in changing economic reality marked by laptops, social media, phones and other consumerist goods is where the film falters in its intent. The agency of Dalit voices is subsumed under the garb of intellectualism of the upper-caste saviour who changes the narrative of the film from misery-filled melancholic images towards hope-resurrecting narrative only to culminate in the adaptation of the utopian idea of Begumpura. The motif of Begumpura, which Ravidas imagined to be a city is imposed on a village struggling under a neoliberal economy. The Dalit populace is organised magically and one acre of land is acquired by Keepa. The politics of social boycott, internal settlements, and bureaucratic corruption are lost from the narrative to restore Begumpura as a filmic imagination.

### ***Landless*: Alienation and the Paradox of Prosperity**

*Landless* presents a 'landless hold of the lens' and turns the spotlight on the issues which remain absent in *Chamm*. Directed by Randeep Maddoke, it opens with a metaphorical question: 'Do the scarecrows have their own land?' followed by wide-angle shots of the lush green fields and landscapes of Punjab, thereby focusing on the paradox of prosperity, which, when probed at deeper, reveals massive faultlines of Punjab's rural economy (*Landless* 00:01:34–00:01:44).<sup>15</sup> It places the scarecrow as representing the potential of Dalit lives that have lost all semblance of dignity through the constraints of caste discrimination, landlessness, and poverty. The scarecrow, a quasi-human object draped in ragged clothes and set up in the fields, becomes synonymous with the *seeri* (bonded labour) (Figure 21.3). Maddoke uses the same metaphor in verses recited



Figure 21.3 'Do the scarecrows have their own land?' from the film *Landless*.

Source: Randeep Maddoke.

later in the film, 'that are crucified on the land belonging to others/ where, their ancestors were smouldered to ashes and/ these fields never embraced them as their own', thereby locating their alienation in the political economy of Punjab, which provides the context for the changing social dynamics along class and caste lines (*Landless* 00:31:14–00:31:49). By situating the question of caste in the land relations of Punjab, the documentary chronicles the struggles of landless Dalit labourers in a society fraught with their systematic oppression.

The Green Revolution, while on the one hand, built the notion of 'prosperous Punjab' and consolidated the position of Jat landowners, and on the other hand, pulverised the ability of Dalits to gain control over the land, which further escalated their vulnerabilities as they became dependent on the upper-caste landholders for their sustenance and employment. Dalits in Punjab constitute 32% of the total population, but they hold just 3.5 % of the total agricultural land (Padhi 2012; Singh 2017). The ideological underpinnings of this dichotomy became even more complicated in the mid-1980s and later in the post-liberal economy, when the gains of technology and mechanisation had already dissipated, thrusting Punjab agriculture into a major crisis. Further, as agriculture became unfeasible, a large number of Dalit labourers were forced to migrate to the cities where their conditions turned even more abysmal. The connection with the village economy and the land, however, did not break for the local agricultural labour. At this juncture, it is particularly significant to recall Dr B. R. Ambedkar's views on land, who argued how land is not simply a matter of economics but also of social status and hence advocated the need to distribute the land to Dalits because 'they must be settled on land so that they might obtain independent means of livelihood, cease to be afraid of anybody, walk with their heads erect and live fearlessly and courageously' (2014: 913). In his writings, Ambedkar asserted that the landlessness of Dalits is 'a product of their alienation from access to land by Hindu society in the pre-colonial period and deprivation from land in the colonial period which was again dominated by caste Hindus' (2014: 909). The overall effect of this process results in the subjugation and landlessness of Dalits who remain at the mercy of their upper-caste landowners. Maddoke, both as part of the farm struggles and understanding the long history of land relations in Punjab, also posits that the caste system and its practice systematically alienate landless farm labour from all the material resources and denies them a dignified existence. However, unlike *Chamm*, it is not a simplistic portrayal of their struggles; rather, the film-maker presents apprehensions and consternation of their condition through photographs, narratives, poetry, and music. He is determined to subvert the same symbols and allusions that popular Punjabi pop music and the mainstream cinematic sphere have used for years to project a picture of prosperity, but the scenes do not miss out the ironies of everyday existence. Maddoke puts the issue of class struggle at the fore while carrying caste alongside. For instance, the song 'Mr. Singh' playing on a tractor, categorically praising the material possession of Jat landowners and celebrating their status as 'regal heirs' of affluent families, and as 'owners of the land and sons of sardars', is juxtaposed with a man riding the bullock cart in the same frame. It not only punctures the notion of boisterous and masculine image of Punjabis that popular cinema has tried to project but also exposes the binaries of possession and dispossession (*Landless* 00:24:22–00:25:10). The performance of the hegemonic control of Jats is typified by their ability to perpetuate their upper-caste identity as synonymous with Punjabi cultural identity through 'strategies of autophony, laying claims to land and landscapes and social value attached to land ownership' (Mooney 2008: 104).

The film consists of loosely related but tightly strung narratives, which, like the French New Wave cinema, follows the principles of time image as expounded by Deleuze. The different images do not subscribe to one coherent account but present multiple facets of Dalit life in Punjab. Maddoke incorporates multiple cinematic techniques to highlight a sense of Dalit subjectivity which has largely been missing from the Indian cinema. He lets his camera move



Figure 21.4 'Landless labourer' from the film *Landless*.

Source: Randeep Maddoke.

closer, often taking tight close-ups which highlight the facial features of the subjects. In one shot, he focuses on the verbal account of a man fixing the camera at his face, while his monologue plays in the background. His sweating face, twitching eyebrows, and straining body make up for this dissociation between the dialogue in the background and the intimate portrait in the foreground (Figure 21.4). The film is skewered with many such conversations. This focus on the bodies of subjects juxtaposed with wide-angle shots of lush green fields bespeaks the precariousness of their existence, which gravitates towards physical and psychological collapse and suicides. The liminal status of Dalits in Punjab has been portrayed in a nuanced manner, which surpasses the emotive and melodramatic tropes that are employed sumptuously in *Chamm*. The objective of *Landless* is not to evoke pity and see Dalits as passive subjects who need a saviour but bring to the forefront the socio-political resistance which has been growing over the last few years.

This resistance is weaved into the hitherto unexplored subject of indebtedness and suicides among the farm labourers, a subject which has largely been understood as the crises of upper-caste farmers.<sup>16</sup> In the process, one notices how women also bear insurmountable agony and distress in this intrinsic relationship between land and caste. This is accomplished through the use of small sequences concentrating on their daily chores and living conditions, their hard labour in the fields, and the sexual violence that comes with it. The film-maker shows acute sensitivity in portraying not only how 'ideas about gendered respectability are also caste-marked' but also how the women cope as they dwindle between resistance and helplessness (Rao 2009: 217). Over the years, protest sites have rendered a strong presence of women, who have been fusing personal agony with the political. Multiple stories of women describing the suicide cases of men of their families, juxtaposed with the shots of the same women attending protests, carrying the photographs of the deceased, pave a new tenor of resistance. However, the deep anxieties of widows and mothers who have to face the brunt of economic and social distress are palpable, which creates an even heightened sense of alienation among them. The growing rage against the oppressive system challenges the might of Jat landowners who, in an attempt to save

the *status quo*, resort to the social boycott of Dalits. Two segments of this film demonstrate how social boycott exacerbates the spaces of vulnerability and alienation. In the first, while historically tracing the presence of caste in Punjab, a lawyer recounts:

My forefathers adopted Sikhism and were its staunch campaigners but even after 10 generations in Sikhism, I could not get rid of my caste identity. I felt that the contradiction lies somewhere else. When they are requested to announce from Gurudwara's speakers that the fishing pond is available for lease, they refuse to do it on the grounds that a religious place cannot take part in an act of violence towards animals. But on the day of social boycott, all the announcements are made from the speakers at Gurudwara.

(Landless 00:55:03–00:55:40)

This is an extension of the 'contradictory reality' that we have argued earlier in the case of *Chamm*, in terms of how religious spaces become the carrier of morality, which they contradict very easily when vested interests of Jats are brought to the equation. In the second segment, an old woman narrates the agony of the entire community living under the dread of social boycott. *Landless* elucidates very clearly that in a society bound by graded hierarchies and asymmetries of power, hegemony can be exercised in such a way as to discipline and subjugate the voices of resistance through the politics of exclusion. Hence, social boycott becomes the epitome of wielding authority.

The film ends on a crucial note. An empty cardboard box of pesticides, tied to a string, is whirling in a circle, putting a question mark on the future of agriculture in the state in general and on the plight of Dalits in particular. It proposes collective farming as a solution but, unlike *Chamm*, it also stipulates caste as a matter of eternal vigilance. Its significance lies in exploring Dalit psyche *vis-à-vis* the neoliberal market and consumer culture through a deep understanding of aesthetics and art.

In conclusion, the three films bring out a rather unexplored phenomenon of alienation. How Dalits are subjugated in Punjab can be understood from these three films which built their universes often overlapping with each other, though unknowingly. One major thread that we can delineate to understand how alienation unfolds is the relation of land with the subjects. Land still holds a significant value to the Dalit population, as it resonates in all the stories. Even after moving to an urban landscape, subjects could not abdicate their relation to the village economy which is directly linked with the land. One common solution that functions is redistribution of land; a cause traditionally configured as a Marxist solution in the subcontinent, which even Dr B. R. Ambedkar prophesied. However, Maddoke presents apprehensions to the cause and puts forward the idea of witnessing caste through the lens of 'eternal vigilance'. These three films become powerful markers of the politico-historically engendered rural-urban alienation and the traps of the political economy underpinning rapid economic growth in post-green revolution in Punjab. *AGDD* punctures the idea of how urban spaces are often projected as places of prosperity and affluence, whereas *Chamm* stands at a juncture where the migration to cities still holds promise. The absence of Ambedkar as an icon looms throughout the space and can be sensed with the iconography and sloganeering of protests for land rights in Punjab<sup>17</sup>. As we have argued earlier how Punjab has a liminal state of 'contradictory realities', this unique predicament is one of the many reasons why Ambedkar or any other major Dalit icon is still missing from the space and Dalit identity is struggling to assert itself.

All three films have their niche audiences which respond to the underlying philosophical frameworks upon which the directors built their works. *AGDD*, with influences from the New wave cinema of India, was lauded in International film festivals, claiming to present the story of

the marginalised communities. But it was marginalised in Punjab where the audience remains aloof to the oeuvre of Gurvinder Singh. *Landless* was the staple of university students and Marxist film festivals who debated amongst themselves the importance of land or lack thereof. Maddoke could not get the same response from the Punjabi audience who, for reasons known only to them, chose to ignore the gut-wrenching and bitter reality of landlessness in Punjab. *Chamm* with its agitprop mode was shown in protest sites throughout Punjab. These films raise important questions to their respective audiences. Yet, one cannot help but question the strict demarcation of cinema in the larger framework of art and its function to understand the everlasting conundrum of caste and its relation with space.

## Notes

- 1 Since its inception in the early 1930s with *Sheila: Pind ki Kudi* (1935), Punjabi cinema has gone through different phases, in which the filmic imagination has conceded various influences, from adapting myths and love legends onto the screen to strengthening the notion of Nehruvian socialism (1940–1950s), from celebrating the religious beliefs to creating slapstick comedies (1960–1970s), from Jatt-centric narratives to films focusing on the diaspora (1980s–2000s), to name a few (Parmar 2013; Garg 2019; Kaur and Singh 2019). In its long history, *Chamm Pardesi* (1981) and *Marhi Da Deeva* (1989) are the only exceptions that broach the subject of caste for the first time in films.
- 2 The Jats, with 35 percent of the total population of Punjab, dominate the socio-political spheres of the state. Traditionally considered as a low-caste group, the Jats entered into the fold of Sikhism during the time of Guru Arjun in great numbers and rose to the position of a land-owning aristocracy during the time of Maharaja Ranjit Singh and the British rule. Their hegemony weakened the position of other castes in Punjab (Puri 2003; Sharma 2012).
- 3 Most of the films in the 1980s and 1990s were centred around the character of Jats and valorised their hegemonic masculinity in terms of both their caste identity and ownership of land, clearly visible from the titles of a large majority of films like *Putt Jattan De* (1982), *Yaari Jatt Di* (1987), *Jatt te Zameen* (1987) *Anakh Jattan Di* (1990), *Jor Jatt Da* (1991), and *Jatt Jeyona Morh* (1992) (Gill 2012; Sevea 2014).
- 4 Horowitz, Asher. 'Marx's Theory of Alienation'. [www.yorku.ca/horowitz/courses/lectures/35\\_marx\\_alienation.html](http://www.yorku.ca/horowitz/courses/lectures/35_marx_alienation.html). Accessed on October 12, 2020.
- 5 Jaaware argues that understanding of caste 'fuses together spatial and temporal metaphors', wherein the spatial connotes a belief in hierarchical social system and temporality is conveyed through different segmentations of backward and forward castes (2019: 214).
- 6 The myth states that the Asuras and Devtas churned out the holy nectar from the sea only for the Hindu God Vishnu to dispense it solely to the Devtas keeping Asuras estranged from their labour. In revolt, one particular Asura disguised himself as a Devta and consumed the nectar. Upon finding this, Vishnu beheaded him and thus 'Rahu' and 'Ketu' emerged from his head and torso. On every solar and lunar eclipse Rahu and Ketu run amok on their chariot, pulled by blind horses to avenge the unfair dispensation provided to them on that inequitable day, and thus, on days of eclipses, Dalits in Punjab go around and ask for alms in the name of the blind horse (Nayar 2016: xiv).
- 7 One of the key figures of the New Wave Cinema in India, Mani Kaul set a new benchmark with his innovative film-making techniques in films like *Uski Roti* (1969), *Duvidha* (1973), and *Satah se Uthata Adami* (1980). For him, the process of making a film is embedded in time and a certain quality of attention as he says, 'I wish to place myself in a particular sense of time and let space be, grow' (2013: 18). He was a mentor to Gurvinder Singh and also a creative producer of *AGDD*.
- 8 Emerging in the mid-1990s, the term 'geographies of exclusion' 'refers to the subtle and not so subtle signals that some social groups are not welcome in urban and rural spaces and thus experience socio-spatial exclusion' (Tchoukaleyska 2017: 1).
- 9 Iqbal Sevea has written extensively on how Jat-centric masculinity prevails by 'demonstrating its superiority not only over women but also over "other" men', resulting in either other caste groups forced to exhibit their ability to match hegemonic masculinity or in emasculation (2014: 131).
- 10 Gursharan Singh (1929–2011) was a progressive director of Punjabi plays, who worked towards bringing an alternative form of theatre in Punjab.
- 11 Rajeev Kumar, inspired by the notion of Third cinema, started Sangat Screenings in 2017 to create a space for an alternative viewing for the common people (personal conversation with the director). The

- film has been screened at various protests organised by the *Zameen Prapati Sangarsh Committee* (ZPSC) from 2018 to 2020 in the Malwa region of Punjab and the ongoing farmers agitation at Delhi against the three farm bills.
- 12 In the Punjab Village Commons Land (Regulation) Act of 1961, one-third of the total common land in village is reserved for the scheduled castes. However, upper-caste Jatt landholders subvert the rules by bidding for the land through their dummy candidates. Over the last few years, Dalits have raised their voice in a few districts of Malwa region of Punjab to get their share of the common land.
  - 13 The bhakti poet, Sant Ravidas (1450–1520), first formulated a utopian vision of society in his song ‘Begumpura’. Begumpura, the city without sorrow, is a modern society free from the entanglements of class and caste. Gail Omvedt in her book, *Seeking Begumpura*, writes, ‘[the poem] was an expression, in the early modern age of a utopia. In some ways, it seems to stand alone, yet it was a harbinger of the kind of social vision that would underline all the later struggles and theorizing of anti-caste intellectuals. Begumpura was, for Ravidas, an imagined city, without geographical location, without a history: it was to be a later task to build in space and time’ (Omvedt 2011: 7).
  - 14 Paramjit Judge, in his paper ‘Religion, Caste, and Communalism in Punjab’, has argued in detail on how the caste stratification among the non-Hindus is qualitatively distinct from that of the Hindus (2002). Surinder S. Jodhka also calls attention to the fact that caste has invariably been ‘seen in unitary terms, as a pan-Indian reality without any significant variations in its structure and ideology’ (2004: 165).
  - 15 ‘Paradox of Prosperity’ is the title of the still-photography project for which Maddoke received Sohan Qadri Fellowship by Chandigarh Lalit Kala Akademi in 2013 and which later became the basis for *Landless*.
  - 16 Only a few studies are available on the indebtedness and suicides among the farm labourers in Punjab. A survey report published by Punjab Khet Mazdoor Union in 2017 brought to light the increasing burden of debt on the agricultural labour, role of banks and cooperative societies, private moneylenders, and microfinance agencies as some of the reasons for the same.
  - 17 Based on conversations with Prof. Paramjit Judge, Prof. Jatinder Singh (Assistant Professor, Punjabi University, Patiala), and Mukesh Malaud (ZPSC).

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